

Blacker Vignoles was called upon for an assessment in 1842. He presented a detailed report on how the construction of railways in India was perfectly feasible. He referred to the availability of good-quality labour and raw materials in India which, in his opinion, was better than in England. He also drew attention to the potential role of railways in military as well as in commercial matters, primarily for cheap distribution of manufactured goods from Britain, developing local markets, and attractive returns. He proposed an elaborate plan for a rail line connecting Bombay and Calcutta, which would pass through highly fertile and populated regions as well as districts rich in coal and iron.

The trend continues

Many other reports were submitted to the Court of Directors advocating the construction of railways in India. Captain JR Western of the Bengal Engineers proposed a railway line from Calcutta to the Upper Provinces. These preliminary discussions planted the seed of introducing the railways in India and the railway mania finally began to touch the Indian shores.



▲ **This lithograph shows bales of cotton** in Bombay ready to be exported to the cotton mills in Lancashire. These were to supplement shortages caused by the blockage of southern ports of the US during the American Civil War (1861–65).